MICAH

Conversational Version

1:**1**A Message from the LORD to Micah from Moresheth
at **the Time of Jotham, Ahaz, *and* Hezekiah, Kings of Judah.**
What He Saw About Samaria and Jerusalem

Judgment Against Samaria and Jerusalem

2Listen, every nation;
listen, world and everybody in it.
Let the Lord GOD testify against you from his holy Temple.
3He's coming down from his place
to walk on the mountaintops.
4The mountains will mash down under his feet
and cascade into the valleys—
like wax in a fire or
water rushing on a slope. **Mic 1:1-4**
5That's because Jacob rebelled
and Israel sinned.
Where's Jacob's rebellion?
Isn't it *in* Samaria?
Where's Judah's *main* high place?
Isn't it *in* Jerusalem?
6I'll make Samaria a pile of ruins in the countryside,
a place to plant vineyards.
I'll drag the stones *of its walls* down to the valley
and expose its foundations.
7I'll smash its idols,
and burn everything in it.
I'll destroy its images
because they came from a prostitute's pay;
that's all they'll be. **Mic 1:5-7**

8Because of this, I'll mourn and wail,
and walk around barefoot and naked.
I'll howl like a jackal
and moan like an owl.
9My people's wound is too deep to heal;
it's penetrated into Judah

all the way up to Jerusalem's gates.
10Don't "tell" it in Gath;
don't weep at all;
roll in the "dust" at Beth-leaphrah.
11Just move on *into captivity*
naked and embarrassed, residents of Shaphir;
the people in Zaaman don't dare "come outside" its wall;
there's mourning in Beth-ezel
because its people have no back up. **Mic 1:8-11**

12Those living in Maroth grow weak waiting for relief,
because "bitter" calamity from the LORD
is reaching the gates of Jerusalem.
13Harness a "team of horses" to a chariot and flee,
people in Lachish, where Zion's sin came from,
where Israel's rebellious acts spread from *into Judah*.
14Send farewell gifts to Moresheth-gath;
the houses in Achzib have "deceived" the kings in Israel.
15I'll bring a "conqueror" on you, people of Mareshah;
Israel's leaders will flee to *the cave of* Adullam.
16Shave off your hair *in despair* for the children you delight in;
make yourself as bald as an eagle
because they're going into exile. **Mic 1:12-16**

Judgment Against Wealthy Oppressors

2:1 Misfortune awaits those who devise sin,
who lie awake plotting schemes in bed!
In the morning they do them
because they can.
2They covet fields and seize them;
they desire horses and take them.
They rob people
and confiscate the property they've inherited.
3So the LORD says,
"I'm devising a catastrophe for this family;
you won't get your necks out of the noose.
You won't keep carrying on arrogantly;
it'll be a terrible time for you.
4Your enemies *will taunt you with a proverb*

and wail a bitter dirge in mockery,
'We're ruined!
God *is reapportioning our things.*
He's taking them away from us
and giving our fields to apostates!'
5*So you won't have anyone stretching out a surveying line*
for you by lot in the LORD*'s assembly.* **Mic 2:1-5**

6*"'Don't preach about such things,' they say;*
'disgrace won't catch up with us.'
7*Are you* really *saying such a thing, House of Jacob?*
Isn't the LORD*'s Spirit patient?*
Does he do such things?
Don't his words do good
for those who do right?
8*My people rise up against my people;*
they strip robes off the peaceful,
off of people that go along innocently
with no thought of fighting.
9*They evict my people's women from their pleasant homes*
and forever strip away from their children
the splendor I would give them.
10*Get up and get out of here!*
this is no longer a place to rest;
there's sinfulness here
that brings painful destruction.
11*If a liar full of hot air tells you*
he'll preach about the fun of wine and alcohol,
he'll certainly get a hearing from you! **Mic 2:6-11**

12*"I'll assemble you, Jacob, remnant of Israel,*
and put you together like sheep in a fold;
like a flock in its pasture,
you'll be a noisy crowd in your land.
13*The One that opens the gate will lead you out;*
you'll break out of exile through it.
Your King will go out ahead of you,
the LORD *at the lead."* **Mic 2:12-13**

Judgment Against Israel's Leaders

3:1I said,
"Listen, leaders of Jacob, rulers of Israel.
Aren't you supposed to know what's good,
2*you that hate good and love evil,*
who skin my people alive,
pull the meat off their bones,
3*eat their flesh,*
break up their bones in pieces,
and chop them up for the pot
like meat in a kettle?"
4You'll call out to the LORD,
but he won't answer you;
he'll turn away from you
because of all your sins. **Mic 3:1-4**

5The LORD says this about *you* prophets
that mislead my people:
"When you have something to eat,
you prophesy peace;
But you declare holy war against anyone
that doesn't feed you.
6*Consequently, you'll have nights without visions,*
darkness without fortunetelling.
The sun will set on you prophets;
the day will get dark over you.
7*You seers will be put to shame;*
you fortunetellers will be disgraced.
You'll have to cover your mouths in humiliation
because I won't answer you."

8But I'm filled with power—
with the Spirit of the LORD—
with justice and courage
to declare to Jacob his transgression,
to Israel his sin. **Mic 3:5-8**

9Listen, leaders of Jacob, rulers of Israel,
who abhor justice and twist the truth,
10who build Zion with bloodshed

and Jerusalem with violence.
11You leaders render verdicts for a bribe;
you priests teach for hire;
you prophets tell fortunes for money.
Yet you *want to* rely on the LORD and say,
"The LORD's with us, right?
Catastrophe won't happen to us."
12So, because of you,
they'll plow Zion like a field;
Jerusalem will become a pile of ruins;
the Temple mount will be a full-grown forest. **Mic 3:9-12**

The Mountain of the LORD

4:1 In the last days,
the mountain the LORD's Temple's on
will be the tallest mountain.
It will loom above the hills,
and the people from many nations will stream to it.
2They'll say,
"Let's go up to the LORD's mountain,
to the Temple of Jacob's God,
so he can teach us his ways,
and we can follow in his paths."
The Law will go out from Zion,
the LORD's message from Jerusalem.
3He'll mediate between many nations
and settle disputes between powerful countries far away.
They'll hammer their swords into plowshares
and their spears into pruning hooks.
Nation won't attack nation
or train for war anymore.
4Everyone will sit under their own vine and fig tree,
and nobody will make them afraid,
the LORD has said so. **Mic 4:1-4**
5The nations conduct themselves
in the name of their gods;
we will follow the LORD our God forever.

Israel's Future Rescue from Exile

6 *"At that time,"* the LORD says,
"I'll assemble the lame
and gather the exiles that I've oppressed.
7 *I'll make the lame a remnant*
and the exiles a powerful nation.
I'll reign over them on Mount Zion permanently.
8 *Your former dominion will revert to you,*
tower of the flock, hill of Zion, kingdom of Jerusalem.
Mic 4:5-8

9 *"Now why are you crying out?*
Don't you have a king?
Has your advisor perished
and agony seized you as in childbirth?
10 *Writhe and groan, inhabitant of Zion,*
like a woman in labor,
because you'll leave this city
to live in the open country,
and go to Babylon.
But *I'll rescue you*
and redeem you from your enemies there.

11 *Now many nations have gathered against you, saying,*
'Let's desecrate it;
let's take pride in destroying Zion.'
12 *But they don't know what I'm thinking*
or understand my purpose,
because I'm going to gather them up
like bundles for a threshing floor.
13 *Get up and thresh, Zion.*
I'll give you iron horns and bronze hoofs
so you can pulverize many nations
and the wealth of their unjust gain you can devote to me,
the Lord of the whole world. **Mic 4:9-13**

A Promised Ruler from Bethlehem

5:1 ***"Muster your troops,*** **Jerusalem*****;***
your enemies are laying siege against you;
they'll hit Israel's leader in the face with a rod.
2 ***But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,***

though you're small among Judah's clans,
you'll have a ruler come out of you on my behalf in Israel **[Mt 2:6]**.
His origins are from long ago, from ancient times."
3*Israel* will be abandoned
till the one that's in labor has the child;
then the rest of his relatives
will come back *from exile*.
4He'll stand up and shepherd his flock
with the power and majesty of the LORD his God;
they'll *be able to* remain secure
because at that time he'll be great everywhere.
5He'll give us peace. **Mic 5:1-5a**

When the Assyrians invade our land
and overrun fortresses,
we'll fight back
with seven shepherds, eight princes leading us.
6They'll shepherd Assyria with the sword,
the land of Nimrod with swords drawn.
The LORD will deliver us from them
when they attack our land
and try to tramp all over our territory.

A Remnant to Be Delivered

7Then the remnant of Jacob *left in the land*
will live among many nations
like dew from the LORD,
like showers on grass
that mortals can't restrain,
that no one can delay. **Mic 5:5b-7**
8The remnant *left* in Jacob
will live among many nations
like a young lion in a flock of sheep.
He mauls and mangles as he goes;
no one can stop him.
9He'll raise his hand against his enemies
and wipe them out.

10 *"At that time,"* the LORD says,

"I'll get rid of your horses
and destroy your chariots.
11*I'll demolish your towns*
and tear down your defenses.
12*I'll abolish sorcery;*
you won't have fortunetellers anymore.
13*I'll get rid of your carved images and sacred pillars*
so you won't worship what you've made.
14*I'll pull up your Asherah poles*
and destroy your pagan *cities.*
15*I'll carry out angry revenge*
on nations that refuse to obey." **Mic 5:8-15**

The LORD's Case Against Israel

6:1 Listen to what the LORD says:
"Present to the mountains your case against me*;*
let the hills hear your complaint."
2But then *listen, mountains, to the LORD's complaint,*
you enduring foundations of the world.
He has a suit against his people;
he'll bring charges against Israel.

3*"What have I done to you, my people?*
How have I wearied you? Answer me.
4*I brought you out of Egypt*
and ransomed you from slavery.
I sent Moses, Aaron, and Miriam to lead you,
5*My people, remember now*
the curse *that Balak, king of Moab, proposed,*
the blessing that Balaam son of Beor answered with,
the laws that led you *from Shittim to Gilgal,*
so you could learn about my faithfulness." **Mic 6:1-5**

6What should I bring to the LORD?
What should I bow with before God on high?
Should I come to him with burnt offerings
and yearling calves?
7Does the LORD delight in thousands of rams,

in 10,000 rivers of olive oil?
Am I to present my firstborn for my transgression,
the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?
8*No*, he's told you what's good:
what does the LORD require from you
but to do good, love kindness,
and walk humbly with him? **Mic 6:6-8**

Israel's Guilt and Punishment

9The LORD will call out to the city—
it's wise to respect him—
"Listen, tribe and city council.
10*Can I overlook the wealth gained from cheating*
that's in sinners' houses
and the short measure that's accursed?
11*Can I acquit a* businessman *that uses dishonest scales*
and a bag of false weights?
12*The rich in the city extort;*
its residents lie and deceive. **Mic 6:9-12**

13*So I'll send diseases to strike you down,*
and bring you to ruin for your sins.
14*You'll eat, but you won't be satisfied;*
there'll be hunger among you.
You'll store up for safe keeping,
but I'll deliver most of it to the sword.
15*You'll plant, but not harvest;*
you'll tread olives, but not anoint yourself with the oil;
you'll tread *grapes, but not drink the wine.*
16*You've followed the statutes of* sinful *Omri*
and the example of Ahab;
you've taken their advice.
So I'll deliver you to destruction
and your people to ridicule;
you'll endure the nations' scorn." **Mic 6:13-16**

Israel's Misery Turned to Hope

7:1 Misfortune is waiting for me!
I feel like people that pick fruit and gather grapes

but have no clusters to eat
or first-ripe figs to satisfy their hunger.
2 Godly people have disappeared;
there aren't any good ones left.
They all premeditate murder;
each hunts the other with a net.
3 Both hands do evil well,
officials and judges both demand bribes,
influential people vie for preferential treatment;
together they weave injustice. **Mic 7:1-3**
4 The best of them are like briars;
the most godly *are* like a thorn hedge.
They can post a watchman,
but their punishment will still come;
their confusion is at hand.
5 Don't trust your neighbor,
don't confide in a friend,
be careful what you tell your wife.
6 Son treats father with contempt;
daughter defies mother,
daughter-in-law defies mother-in-law;
people have enemies in their own families. **Mic 7:4-6**

7 But I will look to the LORD;
I'll wait for God, who keeps me safe.
He'll listen to me.
8 Don't gloat over me, adversary.
Though I fall, I'll get up;
though I live in the dark, the LORD's my light. **Mic 7:7-8**

9 I'll bear the LORD's indignation
because *admittedly* I've sinned against him;
then he'll give me justice *against my enemy*.
He'll bring me out to the light,
and I'll *be able to* see his goodness.
10 As a result, my enemy will see *it too*
and be put to shame who said,
"Where's the LORD your God?"
I'll watch while he's tramped on

like dirt on a road.

11It'll be a time, *Israel*, for rebuilding your walls
and extending your boundaries,
12a day when people come to you
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt—
from Egypt to the Euphrates,
from sea to sea and mountain to mountain.
13But *first* the land will become desolate
because of what its people have done. **Mic 7:9-13**

14Shepherd your people with your staff,
your flock that lives alone in a woods
surrounded by productive fields.
Let them pasture in Bashan and Gilead
like they did in the old days.
15*"I'll show you amazing miracles
like I did when you came out of Egypt."*
16Nations will see *them*
and be embarrassed at their own weakness.
They'll put their hand over their mouth *in awe*,
and their ears will pop.
17They'll lick dust like a snake,
like a reptile in the dirt.
They'll come cringing out of their fortresses
and turn to the LORD our God. **Mic 7:14-17**

The LORD's Compassion for Israel

18What God is like you, that pardons sin
and passes over the rebellious acts
the remnant of his permanent possession has done?
19You'll show us mercy again,
tread our iniquities underfoot,
throw our sins in the sea.
20You'll show *covenant* faithfulness to Jacob,
enduring love to Abraham
like you swore to our ancestors so long ago. **Mic 7:18-20**

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